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Developing Arguments for the Persuasive Speech

Part I The Toulmin Model and Claims

An argument is a series of statements in support of a claim, assertion, or proposition. We commonly think of arguments as occurring between different perspectives or viewpoints with the goal of changing someone's mind. Arguments are important when persuading, but you should have clear evidence and explanations for any type of information sharing.

All speech types require proof to demonstrate the reliability of their claims. Remember, when you speak, you are being an advocate and selecting information that you find relevant to your audience, so arguments are necessary to, at a bare minimum, build in details about the topic's importance.

With speeches that primarily inform, a sound argument demonstrates the relevance and significance of the topic for your audience. In other words, "this is important information because..." or "here's why you should care about this." If you are giving a ceremonial speech, you should provide examples of your insights. In a speech of introduction, for example, you may claim that the speaker has expertise, but you should also provide evidence of their previous accomplishments and demonstrate why those accomplishments are significant.

For each speech type, a well-crafted speech will have multiple arguments throughout. Yes, your thesis statement is central to speech, and your content should be crafted around that idea – you will use your entire speech to prove the reliability of that statement. You will also have internal arguments, i.e. your speech's main points or the "meat" of your speech.

All speech types require arguments, and all arguments use the rhetorical appeals of ethos, pathos, and logos to elicit a particular feeling or response from your audience.

Ethos, or establishing your credibility as a speaker, is necessary for any speech. If you're informing the audience about a key topic, they need to know that you're a trustworthy and reliable speaker. A key way to prove that credibility is through crafting arguments that are equally credible. Using reliable and well-tested evidence is one way to establish ethos.

Using reason or logic, otherwise known as logos, is also a key rhetorical appeal. By using logos, you can select logical evidence that is well-reasoned, particularly when you're informing or persuading.

Pathos, or emotional appeals, allows you to embed evidence or explanations that pull on your audience's heartstrings or other feelings and values. Pathos is common in ceremonial speeches, particularly speeches that eulogize or celebrate a special occasion.

All three rhetorical appeals are important mechanisms to motivate your audience to listen or act.

All three should be done ethically and with the speech context and audience in mind.

Regardless of which rhetorical proof you use, your arguments should be well-researched and well-structured. Below, we explore the structure of an argument in more detail.

The Structure: Claim, Evidence, Warrant

Arguments have the following basic structure:

- Claim: the main proposition crafted as a declarative statement.
- Evidence: the support or proof for the claim.
- Warrant: the connection between the evidence and the claim.

Each component of the structure is necessary to formulate a compelling argument.

The Toulmin Model

British Philosopher, Stephen Toulmin, created the “Toulmin Model” – a model that describes the structure of an argument or method of reasoning. Claim, evidence, and warrant are, if done well, necessary to create a good argument (O’Connor, 1958).

Evidence and warrants are the specifics that make your ideas, arguments, assertions, points, or concepts real and concrete by relating the information to your audience. Not all audiences are compelled by the same evidence, for example, so creating a well-structured argument also means being responsive to audiences.

Consider going to lunch with a friend. Your friend suggests a restaurant that you have not heard of, so you request some additional information, proof, or evidence of their choice. We could map the argument like this:

- Claim: “Let’s go to Jack’s Shack for lunch.”
- Evidence: “I have been there a few times and they have good servers.”

So far, your friend is highlighting service as the evidence to support their claim that Jack’s Shack is a good choice for lunch. However, the warrant is still missing. For a warrant, they need to demonstrate why good service is sufficient proof to support their claim. Remember that the warrant is the connection. For example:

- Warrant: “You were a server, so I know that you really appreciate good service. I have never had a bad experience at Jack’s Shack, so I am confident that it’s a good lunch choice for both of us.”

In this case, they do a good job of both connecting the evidence to the claim and connecting the argument to their audience – you! They have selected evidence based on your previous experience as a server (likely in hopes to win you over to their claim!).

Using “claim, evidence, and warrant” can assist you in verifying that all parts of the argumentative structure are present. Below, we dive deeper into each category.

Claims

A claim is a declarative statement or assertion—it is something that you want your audience to accept or know. Like we’ve mentioned, your thesis statement is a key claim in your speech because it’s the main argument that you’re asking the audience to consider.

Different claims serve different purposes. Depending on the purpose of the argument, claims can fall into one of three types:

Claims of Fact

A claim of fact makes an assertion about something that can be proved or disproved with factual evidence. However, keep in mind the basic quality of claims, that they have to be debatable, and offer an assertion about an issue. So a claim of fact for a logical argument cannot simply consist of a statistic or proven fact. It needs, instead, to focus on an assertion which uses facts to back it up, but for which the evidence might still be debatable.

Inappropriate claim of fact: a statistic or fact that is not debatable:

The month of March 2017 was 1.03°C (1.9°F) above the 20th century average—this marked the first time the monthly temperature departure from average surpassed 1.0°C (1.8°F) in the absence of an El Niño episode in the tropical Pacific Ocean.

Appropriate claim of fact: makes a claim that is debatable using factual evidence

Decreasing carbon dioxide emissions from car exhaust, manufacturing processes, fertilizers, and landfills, while slowing deforestation, may help slow the process of global warming.

Claims of Value

A claim of value argues that something is good or bad, or that one thing is better than another thing.

Sample claims of value

It’s better to apply good nutritional choices at home than teach them at school, because good nutrition then becomes ingrained in the child’s experience.

Although immunotherapy has produced some good results in fighting cancer, overall it is less effective than chemotherapy.

Claims of Policy

A claim of policy argues that certain conditions should exist, or that something should or should not be done, in order to solve a problem.

Sample claims of policy

The city's board of education should institute an honors program not only for high school students, but for elementary and junior high school students as well.

Just as smoking ads have been banned in order to decrease the urge to engage in an unhealthy behavior, soda ads should be banned for the same reason.

No matter the type of claim, you will usually combine many types of support for that claim in order to write a logical argument, including facts, case studies, reasons, personal interviews, and more, as appropriate.

It's important to develop confidence around writing and identifying your claims. Identifying your main ideas will allow you to then identify evidence in support of those declarative statements. If you aren't confident about what claims you're making, it will be difficult to identify the evidence in support of that idea, and your argument won't be structurally complete. Remember that your thesis statement, your main claim, but you likely have claims throughout your speech (like your main points).

Vocabulary

序号	单词	中文释义	例句
1	statement	陈述; 声明	The company's annual report includes a statement on its future development plans.
2	assertion	断言; 主张	Her assertion that technology boosts productivity is supported by recent data.
3	proposition	提议; 命题	The professor introduced a new proposition about economic growth at the seminar.
4	perspective	视角; 观点	From an international perspective, the trade agreement benefits both countries.
5	explanation	解释; 说明	The scientist provided a clear explanation for the phenomenon observed in the experiment.
6	reliability	可靠性; 可信度	Consumers value the reliability of electronic products when making purchases.
7	advocate	倡导者; 支持	She has long been an advocate for equal access to education for all children.
8	significance	重要性; 意义	The discovery of renewable energy sources holds great significance for humanity.
9	inform	告知; 通知	The government issued a notice to inform the public of the new traffic regulations.
10	ceremonial	仪式性的; 礼节性的	The president attended a ceremonial event to mark the country's founding anniversary.
11	insight	洞察力; 见解	His book offers valuable insights into the challenges of modern society.
12	expertise	专业知识; 专长	The team's technical expertise helped solve the complex engineering problem.
13	accomplishment	成就; 成绩	Her academic accomplishments have earned her international recognition.
14	well-crafted	精心构思的; 巧妙设计的	The well-crafted speech resonated deeply with the audience.

序号	单词	中文释义	例句
15	internal	内部的; 内在的	The company needs to address its internal management issues to improve efficiency.
16	appeal	吸引力; 呼吁	The charity's appeal for donations received a positive response from the public.
17	elicit	引出; 激发	The interviewer asked questions to elicit honest answers from the candidates.
18	trustworthy	值得信赖的; 可靠的	A trustworthy friend is someone you can rely on in difficult times.
19	embed	嵌入; 植入	The new software embeds advanced security features to protect user data.
20	heartstrings	心弦; 情感	The story of the orphan's struggle tugged at the heartstrings of the audience.
21	eulogize	颂扬; 赞美	The speaker eulogized the late leader's contributions to the country's development.
22	mechanism	机制; 机理	The body has a natural mechanism to defend against foreign pathogens.
23	motivate	激励; 激发	The manager used various methods to motivate employees to work harder.
24	ethical	道德的; 伦理的	Businesses should adhere to ethical standards in their operations.
25	well-researched	研究充分的	The article is a well-researched analysis of global economic trends.
26	well-structured	结构清晰的	A well-structured essay is easier for readers to follow and understand.
27	claim	主张; 声称	The company's claim of zero carbon emissions has been verified by third-party audits.
28	warrant	正当理由; 依据	The court ruled that there was sufficient warrant to proceed with the investigation.
29	institute	制定; 设立	The government plans to institute new regulations to protect endangered species.
30	deforestation	森林砍伐; 滥伐	Deforestation in the Amazon has accelerated due to agricultural expansion.

Exercise

I Fill in the blanks using the most appropriate words from the vocabulary.

- The international community needs to establish a effective _____ to monitor global carbon emissions.
- The judge stated that there was no legal _____ to arrest the suspect without evidence.
- The university plans to _____ a new program to promote interdisciplinary research.
- _____ in tropical regions has led to a sharp decline in the number of native bird species.
- Tech companies are under increasing pressure to deal with _____ concerns regarding user data privacy.

II Circle the most suitable choice to replace the underlined word.

- The manager's assertion that the team would meet the deadline was met with skepticism.
A. perspective B. proposition C. claim D. insight
- The report highlights the significance of investing in renewable energy sources.
A. importance B. reliability C. mechanism D. content
- The well-crafted article received positive reviews from readers and critics alike.
A. multiple B. sound C. logical D. trustworthy
- The government plans to institute stricter rules on air pollution control.

A. inform B. establish C. embed D. motivate

5. The company's response to the public's concerns was prompt and effective.

A. feeling B. reaction C. appeal D. value

III Translate the following sentences into English.

1. 这个城市的新交通计划是基于对市民出行需求的深入洞察力而制定的。
2. 为了解决环境问题，国际社会需要采取多个层面的合作行动来遏制森林砍伐。
3. 这位环保倡导者毕生致力于推广可持续的生活方式和绿色价值观。
4. 合乎逻辑的论点必须有充分的事实依据和清晰的推理过程来支撑其主张。
5. 从青少年的视角来看，社交媒体不仅是娱乐工具，更是重要的社交平台。